

Brief: Financial Department Use Cases — Canonical Documents, Accounts Payable, and Document Control

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from Human (project lead), based on conversation with a CFO

to Ambassador (lead), Developer, Architect, Sherpa

type Strategy + use case brief — financial workflows, SME market, document control

Context

The human had lunch with a friend who is a CFO. Unprompted, the CFO started proposing use cases for SG/Send in financial operations. This is the second time a business professional has independently mapped SG/Send to their workflow problems (the first was the customer who saw it as secrets management for AI agents). When people spontaneously design solutions using your product, you're solving a real problem.

The sweet spot: **SME to mid-size companies** where manual processes still dominate, where ERP solutions are clunky and over-complicated, and where spending hundreds or thousands on a problem is reasonable but tens of thousands is not. SG/Send's price point (£1/GB, credit-based) is a fraction of enterprise document management solutions.

The Core Insight: It's Not Just Security — It's Control and Identity

The CFO's reaction wasn't primarily about encryption. Three things resonated:

1. **Who sent it:** Verifiable sender identity. The invoice was actually sent by the supplier, not by a fraudster.
2. **Who can read it:** Access control via encryption. Only the intended recipients can open the document.
3. **Which version is canonical:** There's one live version. No 50 copies scattered across inboxes. Everyone is guaranteed to be looking at the latest.

These map to three SG/Send capabilities: PKI signing (who sent it), public-key encryption (who can read it), and the single-link model (canonical version — the link always resolves to the current document).

Use Case 1: Canonical Document Control (Price Lists)

The Problem

A company has a price list shared with 30 partners. Today: the price list is emailed as a PDF. Each partner has a copy. When prices change, a new PDF is emailed. Some partners miss the update. Some have old versions. Some forward the PDF to people who shouldn't have it. Nobody knows which version each partner is working from.

The SG/Send Solution

The price list is uploaded to SG/Send. Each partner gets a link. The link is the canonical version.

Feature	What It Solves
Single link per partner	The partner always accesses the latest version via their link
PKI per-partner access	Only that specific partner can decrypt the document (their public key)
Download prevention	The viewer renders the document without making it easy to download/save/forward
Revocation	The sender revokes the link → the partner can no longer access it. Instant. No "please delete the PDF I sent you."
Access analytics	The sender sees: which partners opened the price list, when, how often. Who hasn't looked at it in 6 months?
Version control	The sender updates the document behind the same link. Partners automatically see the new version.

The "Canonical Version" Positioning

This is a distinct selling point: **"One link. One truth. You control who sees it."** It's not about keeping secrets — it's about making sure everyone is working from the same, current, authorised version of a document. This resonates beyond price lists: contracts, policies, compliance documents, product specs, SLAs.

Use Case 2: Accounts Payable — Invoice Workflow

The Problem

The accounts payable process in most SMEs is a nightmare: invoices arrive via email (mixed with spam), get forwarded to approvers (who lose them), payment details are in PDFs (easy to forge), and matching invoices to purchase orders is manual. Business email compromise (BEC) fraud — where attackers send fake invoices with their own bank details — costs UK businesses billions annually.

The SG/Send Solution

Supplier onboarding: The buyer gives each supplier a private key and a submission link: "When you send an invoice, upload it here, signed with this key."

The workflow:

1. Supplier uploads invoice to their SG/Send submission link
 - Signed with their private key (proves: this supplier sent this)
 - Encrypted with the buyer's public key (proves: only the buyer can read it)
2. Invoice arrives in the buyer's vault, in the supplier's folder
 - Alongside: purchase order, receipts, quotes, due diligence docs
 - Everything in one place, cross-referenceable
3. Buyer sees: verified sender, verified document integrity, audit trail
 - "This invoice was uploaded by Supplier X on March 7 at 14:32"
 - "The bank details in this invoice match the bank details on file"
4. Buyer processes the invoice
 - Marks as "seen", "approved", "paid"
 - Upload payment receipt to the same folder
 - Supplier can see the payment receipt (transparency)

What This Prevents

Threat	How SG/Send Prevents It
Fake invoices (BEC fraud)	Invoice must be signed with the supplier's private key. A fraudster doesn't have the key.
Tampered bank details	Signed document — any modification invalidates the signature
Lost invoices	Everything in the vault folder. No email to lose.
Version confusion	One canonical invoice per transaction. No "which PDF is the right one?"
Delayed payments	Supplier sees when the invoice was viewed and processed. No more "we never received it."

The Friction Balance

The buyer holds the cards. The buyer sets the process. The supplier has to comply (upload to our link, sign with their key). This introduces friction for the supplier — but it's reasonable friction because the buyer is the customer. Suppliers will adopt a process that gets them paid faster and more reliably.

Use Case 3: Sensitive Executive Documents

Board papers, financial results, M&A documents, compensation data — shared among a small group (5-15 people) who need access but the documents must not leak.

SG/Send solution: Per-recipient PKI encryption. Each board member gets access with their key. The sender sees who opened it and when. Revocation is instant. No email forwarding, no "please delete" requests.

Use Case 4: Expense Submissions

Employees submit receipts and expense claims. The employer needs: proof of what was submitted, when, by whom, and an audit trail of approval.

SG/Send solution: Each employee has a submission link. They upload receipts (photo, PDF). Everything is signed (proves who submitted), timestamped (proves when), and stored in a per-employee vault folder. The approver sees the submission, marks it approved, and the employee can see the status.

Content Protection: Making Copying Harder

The Viewer-Based Approach

Because we control the viewer (the recipient sees the document in our web viewer, not in their local PDF reader), we can make copying harder:

Technique	What It Does
No download button	The viewer renders the document but doesn't offer a download. The data stays in the browser.
Disable right-click / copy	Basic protection against casual copying (not foolproof but raises the bar)
Page-by-page loading	Each page is a separate encrypted file. No single download gets the whole document.
Scrambled rendering	Content is delivered in a format that can't be easily imported into a spreadsheet or document editor — it's rendered visually but the underlying data isn't in standard format
IP-locked access	The decryption key is derived partly from the recipient's IP address. The document can only be decrypted from the expected network.
Component-based security	Using the sg-layout Web Components architecture, the viewer component simply doesn't include save/download functionality. The code to save isn't there — not hidden, not disabled, literally absent from the browser.

Threat Model Honesty

We cannot prevent someone taking a photo of their screen with a camera. That's not the threat model. The threat model is:

- Preventing casual forwarding ("oops, sent the price list to the wrong person")
- Preventing bulk copying ("let me just save all 200 pages as a PDF and put it on Dropbox")
- Making it harder than email ("if the path of least resistance is to NOT copy it, most people won't")
- Maintaining an audit trail ("even if someone does access it, we know who and when")

The positioning: "We can't prevent a determined spy from photographing your screen. But we can prevent your price list from ending up in 50 email inboxes, your board papers from being forwarded to personal

Gmail, and your invoices from being tampered with."

Price Point Advantage

SG/Send's credit-based model is dramatically cheaper than enterprise document management:

Solution	Cost	What You Get
Enterprise DMS (DocuSign, Box, SharePoint)	£10,000-£100,000/year	Feature-rich but complex, over-engineered for many SME use cases
SG/Send	£50-£500/year (credit-based)	Encrypted sharing, access control, audit trail, canonical versioning
Manual (email)	£0 direct cost	No control, no audit trail, no security, BEC fraud risk

The question for the CFO: **"Is £500 worth avoiding the next invoice fraud incident? Is it worth knowing that every partner is looking at the correct price list?"**

This is not competing with enterprise solutions on features. It's competing on the axis of: "you have a real problem, the enterprise solution is overkill for your size, and doing nothing is risky."

Acceptance Criteria

Use Case Documentation

#	Criterion
1	Canonical document control use case documented with workflow diagrams
2	Accounts payable use case documented with supplier onboarding flow
3	At least 4 financial department use cases mapped (price lists, invoices, board papers, expenses)
4	Content protection techniques listed with honest threat model

Website and Positioning

#	Criterion
5	Financial department use cases page on sgraph.ai
6	"Canonical document" positioning tested with at least 2 potential customers
7	Price comparison table (SG/Send vs enterprise DMS vs email) on website

Technical Features Required

#	Criterion
8	Viewer-only mode: document renders without download button (per-sender setting)
9	Per-file PKI encryption: different recipients for different files in same share
10	Access analytics: who opened, when, how often
11	Document update behind same link (canonical version control)
12	Upload portal for supplier invoice submission (per-supplier link)

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